

NEWS ANALYSIS
*The Midterms
Feel Like ‘06
Is Back Again*
*An Electorate Stressed
Over War and Prices*

By CARL HULSE
WASHINGTON — The war in the Middle East is increasingly unpopular. So is the president as his numbers dip perilously — a common development in the sixth year of a presidency. Congressional Republicans are embroiled in unsavory scandals. Americans are shelling out big bucks for gas while economic anxiety runs high.

The grim backdrop for November’s midterm elections has created a steep challenge for Republicans and opportunities for Democrats that look much the same as those they encountered in 2006.

Back then, congressional Republicans faced the voters at the midpoint of President George W. Bush’s second term, with the public roiled by the war in Iraq, high fuel prices and a series of ugly accusations against members of the G.O.P. majority on Capitol Hill.

“It is striking,” said Senator Chuck Schumer of New York, the Democratic minority leader and chief architect of his party’s Senate campaign strategy this year and two decades ago. “The analogy is amazing.”

The parallels are not perfect, since politics and campaigns have both changed radically over 20 years. But the comparisons are instructive, as officials in both parties stare down the final months of an election that will determine who controls Congress for the remainder of President Trump’s term.

“This is 2006 2.0,” said Rahm Emanuel, who in 2006 was an ambitious Democratic House member from Illinois and Mr. Schumer’s counterpart across the Capitol as the head of the Democratic Congressional Campaign Committee.

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JIM WILSON/THE NEW YORK TIMES
Democrats’ wins in ‘06 paved Nancy Pelosi’s path to speaker.
PATH TO MAJORITY An unpopular president has opened a door for Senate Democrats. PAGE A10

*An MTV Alum in the Cabinet
Now Stars in the Deal World*

There is a convention, when someone launches a spinoff of a hit TV show, of having the star of the original appear in the pilot to give it a boost. As it is in Hollywood, so it is in Washington.

Thus the first episode of “The Great American Road Trip” — the family-reality-show-meets-sponsor-showcase-meets-political-branding-exercise starring the secretary of transportation, Sean Duffy — includes an Oval Office cameo from President Trump. The former “Apprentice” host, in effusive M.C. mode, grants his blessing to the legacyquel, as

Duffy and his family begin a six-episode tour.

It’s a fitting project for an administration in which camera-readiness is a chief qualification. And it’s a fitting assignment for Duffy and his wife, the Fox News host Rachel Campos-Duffy, both 1990s alums of “The Real World,” the MTV fishbowl series about “what happens when people stop being polite and start getting real.”

Having a video brand is now part of politics. Years ago, the former Alaska governor and vice-presidential candidate Sarah Palin shot “Sarah Palin’s Alaska” and “Amazing America.” Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr.

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NINA RIGGIO FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES
Mary and Zachariah Ben turned to private lenders when a low-interest federal loan to buy land in New Mexico stalled for months.

*Justices Clear
A Path to Curb
Mail-In Voting*

By ABBIE VANSICKLE and ANN E. MARIMOW
WASHINGTON — A divided Supreme Court on Monday allowed the Trump administration to move forward with plans to restrict mail-in voting before the midterm elections.

In an emergency order, the justices said President Trump could proceed with implementing an executive order he had signed, which directed the U.S. Postal Service to help decide which voters should receive mail-in ballots.

Under the executive order, the Department of Homeland Security will also create lists of U.S. citizens that the administration believes could be used to monitor voter rolls for noncitizens.

The decision means the administration can move ahead with planning for restricting the use of mail ballots even as a lower court continues to weigh the legality of Mr. Trump’s executive order.

But with a little more than two months until Election Day — and less time before early voting begins in many states — it remains unclear whether the White House’s rules will be in effect for a midterm election in which control of both chambers of Congress is at stake.

Additional legal action is a near certainty.

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Deaths by Russian A.I.-Guided Drone Are a First

By ANDREW E. KRAMER
ZAPORIZHZHIA, Ukraine — The young woman ran for her life, but it was too late.

A small Russian drone resembling a model airplane swooped down from the sky last month in the city of Zaporizhzhia in southeastern Ukraine. As it tried to navigate toward a gas station, it crashed into a wall and exploded in a hail of shrapnel, killing Tetiana Bubynets, 19, a university student, and two others.

They were among the thousands of Ukrainian civilians who have died in Russian airstrikes, but the circumstances of their deaths came with an ominous twist. The drone that killed them

*Civilian Killings Show
Moscow Adapting
Weapons of War*

was guided by an experimental artificial intelligence system, not a human pilot, according to drone experts, Ukrainian military commanders and the forensic team that examined wreckage from the deadly strike and others in the city.

The drone was programmed by human operators to travel toward a particular gas station, but once it got close, it chose its exact target — most likely propane tanks — on

its own, based on its training to recognize such tanks and strike them, the experts and military officials said.

It is a development long watched for in the war in Ukraine, presaging a dystopian future in which killer robots roam the skies making life-or-death decisions that reduce targets to data points.

“This is a risk for the whole world,” said Col. Serhiy Minaiev, the commander of air defenses in Zaporizhzhia. “In a few years, we will be living in a ‘Terminator’ movie. It’s no joke. Machines are making decisions to strike.”

Analysis of debris from this attack and others in Zaporizhzhia found that the drones had onboard

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HUBERT HAYAUD FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES
A Vehicle’s Second Life in Central America Migrants are working a lucrative, if dangerous, trade by driving junked U.S. cars south. Page A7.

When the Bots Combined Forces to Go Rogue Against OpenAI

By DYLAN FREEDMAN
On July 16, the artificial intelligence company Hugging Face announced on its blog that it had been the target of a cyberattack that was “different from anything we had handled before.” The company, which hosts open-source A.I. models and data sets, said that some of its internal data had been breached by an autonomous agent.

Not knowing who was behind it, Hugging Face reported the intrusion to law enforcement agencies.

OpenAI, a customer of Hugging Face, reached out to see if it had been affected.

The maker of ChatGPT did not realize it at the time, but it was the attack’s perpetrator.

The episode has since become a cautionary tale of how autonomous A.I. systems can run amok. It is also a remarkable, alarming

5 Steps to Defy Limits and Launch Attacks

demonstration of A.I. capabilities that were thought to be in a distant future.

“Unlike normal incidents, which you can maybe trace down to a single day or single effect or single log, this incident involves

actually a team of agents who are working together, finding exploits, sharing them with one another, moving laterally through our systems, through external systems, and doing this over the course of days and weeks,” Eric Wallace, an OpenAI safety researcher, said at a cybersecurity conference this month.

It was an unprecedented attack with an elaborate setup.

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Seats That Take a Stand A lack of benches at Nashville bus stops led a group to create colorful statements, but not all can stay. PAGE A9

B.Q.E. Needs a Fix A.S.A.P. New York City officials have announced a \$4 billion plan for a roadway that needs quick repairs to remain safe. PAGE A15

INTERNATIONAL A4-8
Tariff Threats for Canada President Trump vowed to increase levies on cars, trucks, auto parts and steel to 50 percent as the countries plunged into a trade war. PAGE A6

Crackdown on Coffee Shops In recent weeks, the Iranian police have closed dozens of cafes in an effort to control public space. PAGE A5

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New Mosquito Fears in Africa The malaria-carrying pest is spreading with alarming speed, threatening cities like Lagos and Kinshasa. PAGE D1



SPORTS B6-9
A Closer With No Ending Craig Kimbrel, who is 38 and in his 17th M.L.B. season, says he’ll keep going as long as he believes in himself. PAGE B6

Far From Home in New World For many international students, college football is a big, bewildering introduction to U.S. campus life. PAGE B7

BUSINESS B1-5
The Bundling Battles Begin Platforms have largely moved past trying to gain more subscribers. Now, they’re looking for ways to become the main entry point for all that streaming has to offer. PAGE B1

Making Low-Cost Interceptors For a Florida start-up, becoming a global supplier of counterdrone technology has meant involving the Trumps, a golf course and a new way of doing business. PAGE B1

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David French PAGE A18



ARTS C1-6
Picassos of the Asphalt All over the city’s sidewalks and sewers, colored markings hide in plain sight, telling construction crews where to dig and creating accidental art. PAGE C1

